

Ordering Conceptual Synthesis: The Implications of Cognitive Phenomenology for Syntactic Theory

Abstract

This paper examines methodological foundations for linguistics in terms of phenomenology and the philosophy of science. I argue for explanatory paradigms that model the interdependence of linguistic and extra-linguistic knowledge/faculties for understanding typical sentences. In lieu of set theory or predicate logic formalization, I point out some similarities between natural and computer languages, so that formal structures related to compilers and programming-language implementation may offer useful simplified models for human communication. In particular, I emphasize how surface discourse may be transformed to sequences of operations toward conceptual aggregation/synthesis, while maintaining that most details concerning how concepts are pairwise combined depend on extralinguistic cognitive activity.

1 Introduction

It is clearly true that an important part of human language is governed by rules or structures, ones that can be (at least to a useful extent) formalized and computationally simulated. And yet, language was not designed by committee: claiming that a particular semantic or syntactic pattern has become entrenched is not a complete argument, as if language were intrinsically a collection of formal rules, and we need merely infer them (like reverse-engineering compiled computer code). The question is *why* patterns become entrenched and stay so.

¹ This paper's examples are embedded in its Journal Article Tag Suite (JATS) sources according to a standardized encoding. See the JATS (XML) files for more information.